

French Gothic

Medieval communities took great pride in their churches and cathedrals, especially in northern France, source of the Gothic style. They poured huge funds into them, while professional masons travelled from city to city to build them. Sainte-Chapelle in Paris (1248, opposite) was designed to be more awe-inspiring than any other church in Europe. The resting place of holy relics, including a supposed piece of Christ's Crown of Thorns, it is an example of the Rayonnant style. A mid-Gothic phase inspired by French court style, Rayonnant – 'radiating' – is characterised by rose windows featuring decorative tracery. The walls of Sainte-Chapelle feature vast, brilliantly coloured stained-glass windows, separated only by vividly painted columns.

Close by, Notre Dame de Paris was begun in 1163; its flying buttresses were an afterthought, added to support the high, thin outside walls and roof. Over many years, numerous architects worked on Notre Dame; those of the mid-13th century oversaw the construction of the fine rose windows.

